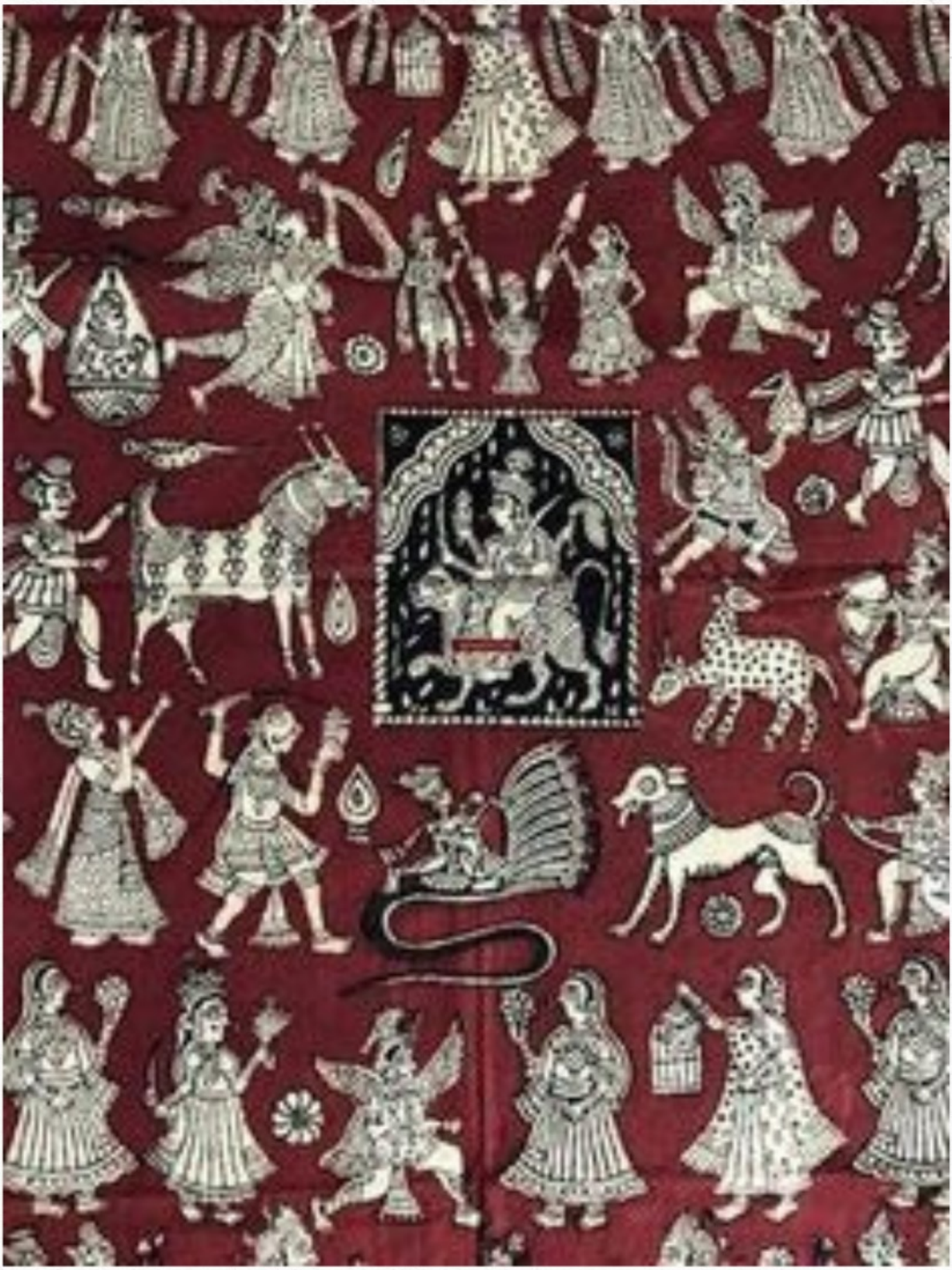


Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

September 2023

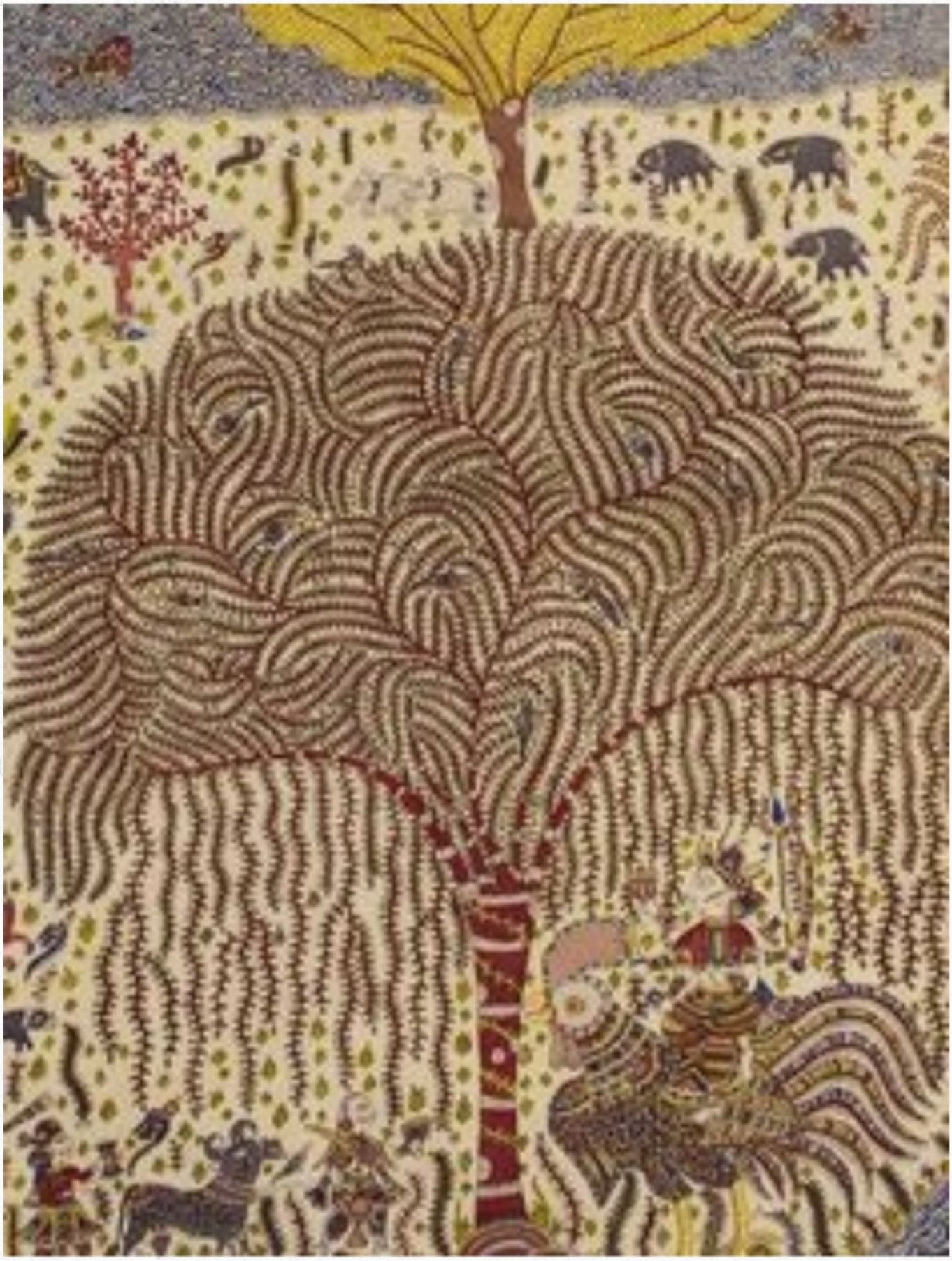


Mata Ni Pachedi

A folk art that grew out of defiance

The Indian repertoire of folk painting covers several styles, from Kalamkari and Patachitra to Madhubani, Pichwai, Gond and Mata Ni Pachedi. All but Gond art have a religious slant, and all but Mata Ni Pachedi are used for decorating not just floors and walls, as was originally done long ago, but several items of home decor today.

Mata Ni Pachedi hand-painted hangings alone are honoured as the holy shrine itself.







The practice started over three centuries ago with the Vaghari community of Gujarat. Marginalized for their nomadic life, they were turned away from temples by the orthodoxy.

Far from being curbed by this harsh decree, the Vaghari leaders were emboldened to create their own 'portable' temples. These became famous as the sacred cloth of Mata ni pachedi ('behind the mother goddess') the intricately painted banners that constitute a shrine to the folk goddess, Vahanvati Mata, worshipped by the Vaghari.

Her iconography shows her seated on a goat, which in turn is placed inside a ship: a goddess who protects travellers and merchants crossing the seas. It's a single theme with scores of brilliant depictions.

See the rise of this intricate art and the patient and brave people who stay inspired by it even after 300 years; in this 10 min documentary.